

FreePCB Editor to Edit and Layout PCBs

Most free or low-cost PCB editors are either limited by pin and layer limits, or have bugs that make them difficult to use. So we have found a better one for you. Read this article to know more about the PCB editor called FreePCB

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FreePCB, as the name suggests, is a free open source Windows program for editing and laying out PCBs. It is a handy tool capable of doing professional quality work, while at the same time remaining very easy to learn and use for beginners.

FreePCB comes with an intuitive GUI and options that allow you to perform almost any task related to PCB designing. It can easily be used for serious designs too, as it can handle multiple (up to 16) copper layers and comprises a Footprint Wizard and Footprint Editor for guiding the process of creating or modifying your footprints.

You can configure the footprints using the various functions that come bundled with the software. I also found an interface to the FreeRoute autorouter program, which relieves you from manually routing each trace in your design, thus making the design process much easier. Let us take a deeper look at the key features.

Key features

The other PCB tools, including some paid ones, can be far too intimidating and overly complex, but FreePCB is quite easy to use and learn. There are enough features in this tool for your PCB design requirements. Let us look at each of the important benefits and how they stack up.

User-friendly tool. Apart from the obvious PCB design functionality, some built-in features also exist

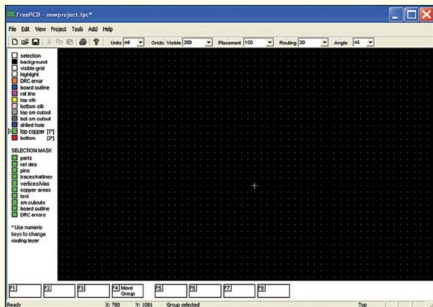


Fig. 1: FreePCB

which make working with FreePCB user-friendly. To list a few, we can start with the 'auto-save' feature. The auto-saved files are stored in a subfolder of the project folder, with incremental file names generating automatically.

File handling gives the advantage of re-usability, groups can be saved as project files and you can paste a project file as a group into another project. Automatic functions such as Check Traces clean up traces for you by combining collinear segments and eliminating zero-length segments. Also, you can make changes in the settings for a pin and applying those to other pins in the Footprint Wizard.

We cannot list all but, using this tool, you will find many other useful

System requirements and installation

Runs on Windows NT/98/Me/2000/XP/2003/Vista/7

Note: Installation file can be found in EFY Plus DVD that came with this magazine. FreePCB is a Windows program, but it can also run on Linux or on Macintosh using Wine or VirtualPC. FreePCB is a lighter tool in terms of memory usage and takes less than 100MB space on the hard drive including the default libraries. The memory requirements can also depend upon the size of your designs, with most of the designs loading and performing operations in less than 100MB of free memory.

features which will make your PCB designing process very easy and efficient.